



A NOTE FROM ALI · UNSCRIPTED SMALL BUSINESS

You Don't Need a Travel Agent — You Need an Advisor

My take on launching an agency, choosing advocacy over booking, and marketing every single trip.

I'm Ali Raymer — a former Title I English teacher, nine years in travel, and the founder of Peace and Pearl Travel Co., which I launched the very week we recorded this episode.

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A NOTE FROM ME

I never planned to sell travel. I was a high-school English teacher fundraising trips for kids who couldn't afford them, until my husband's aunt told me I could do this for people with money. Nine years, one pandemic, and a whole rebuild later, I launched Peace and Pearl Travel Co. — the same week Jeremy and I recorded this. Here's what I'd tell anyone building a service business right now.

CHAPTER 01

Why you need an advisor, not an agent

When Jeremy asked me for an elevator pitch, I flipped it: you don't need a travel agent. Between AI, Expedia, Booking.com and the Southwest app, booking is easy now — and I'm fine saying that out loud. What you actually need is an advisor.

I'm honestly like a marriage counselor. Someone comes to me set on Santorini because of a TikTok, or an Italy honeymoon, and half my job is redirecting them to what actually fits — sometimes Portugal instead of Italy, and they love it more. And when things break, I'm your independent advocate. During COVID cancellations, the people who booked direct were fighting for their own refunds; my clients had me. One client couldn't find a rental car in Greece — she texted me and got an answer, instead of sitting on hold with an Expedia line no one picks up.

CHAPTER 02

My hot take: regulate us like realtors

I compare what I do to a realtor, because it helps people get it — and that leads straight into my hot take: our industry should be more regulated. Realtors need licensing and continuing education. Travel agents don't need either. Anyone can join a host agency, use its license number, and start booking tomorrow.

“Either Disney is getting that extra 10% commission or a small business owner like myself is. And we’re advocating for you on your behalf instead of a Disney travel agent advocating for, let’s be honest, Disney’s behalf.”

— Ali Raymer

So my honest advice is to interview anyone who calls themselves a travel agent. ASTA encourages a “blue check mark”—style verification — basically one simple class — and I’d gladly do continuing ed for the credibility. Because the truth is, a lot of people in this business love to travel but aren’t always going to be there to pick up the phone when you have a problem. I want to be the one who is.

CHAPTER 03

Why I built on a host agency

I'll be the first to tell you the financial side is a hundred percent not my skill set. I'm the creative visionary; I don't like spreadsheets. So I built my agency on top of a host agency that handles the back-end financials and licensing for me.

That means I'm not building clearing authority from scratch. The host makes sure I get paid every two weeks, I'm set up as an S corp, and I pay a local company to run my payroll. My advice to any founder: figure out what your superpower is, then find someone to carry the parts that aren't. Don't force yourself to be great at the thing you'll always resent doing.

CHAPTER 04

How I actually get paid

People are always curious how this works, so here it is. I make money two ways. First, planning and consult fees plus retainers — I charge those on custom, complicated trips, and I'll often waive them for something simple like an all-inclusive honeymoon. Second, commissions, which are driven by my consortium and host-agency relationships and by product loyalty: the more of a product I sell, the higher my commission gets.

“Like I literally sell memories and experiences. So I just don’t think there’s a better industry. I really don’t.”

— Ali Raymer

On average that shakes out to about a 12% yield. And here's the part clients don't always realize — on a lot of products, like Disney and cruises, using me costs you nothing extra, because the supplier pays that commission either way. So that money is going to somebody regardless. It might as well go to someone who's advocating for you.

CHAPTER 05

Do the points — and keep me too

I play the points game myself — I've got two kids and I travel about once a month — so I get it. My advice: pick a card that fits your style, and start with airlines, because flights are the thing I least want to pay for. Then think about your home airport. I'm near Nashville, and BNA has a strong Southwest schedule, so that shapes what makes sense for me.

The myth I want to bust is that points and a travel advisor can't coexist. I have an avid Marriott client — I'll build his whole trip loaded with Marriott stays, let him book those himself to use his points and save money, and I still earn my commission on the boutique hotels and experiences I manage. So do the points, play the game — and still work with an advisor.

CHAPTER 06

Marketing is the gap I refuse to leave

My market splits in two: millennials and Gen X moms scrolling Instagram, and retired boomers with money and time on Facebook. And I think it's imperative to use free social-media marketing on every single trip. I travel about once a month, and I turn each trip into a marketing moment tuned to what my clients actually want — “have you thought about the Peak District in the UK?”

“If I went to the gym and looked at my trainer and he didn't have muscles, I wouldn't go to that gym. But he's buff. He looks good. So I'm like, I need to do the same. I need to be exercising my travel muscle.”

— Ali Raymer

This is the biggest gap I see other advisors leave on the table, and my gym analogy is exactly why. If your advisor never posts their own travels, they're a personal trainer with no muscles. Travel is the easiest, easiest thing in the world to talk about and sell — so staying quiet about it makes no sense to me.

CHAPTER 07

AI is already sending me clients

This shift isn't theoretical for me — it's already happening. Clients used to say they found me on Google. This past year, they increasingly say they found me through AI: "I asked Gemini and you came up, you were the first one." Even my traditional boomer parents use it now.

So I don't just think SEO-minded anymore. I think about what AI is going to be looking for. If you run a small business, that's the shift I'd start preparing for today — the way people discover you is changing, and I'd rather be first in the answer than buried on page two.

IDEAS WORTH STEALING

Seven things I'd tell any founder

- 01** Sell the relationship, not the booking — anyone can book; few will advocate.
- 02** Explain your role with an analogy people already trust (advisor = realtor).
- 03** Outsource what isn't your superpower — a host agency can be your back office.
- 04** Know your own economics: ~12% yield, two revenue streams, loyalty drives the rate.
- 05** Don't fight the points game — design the trip around it and still get paid.
- 06** Market from lived proof: post every trip, or you're a trainer with no muscles.
- 07** Optimize for AI discovery, not just Google — clients already find me there.

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